

POPULAR CULTURES

in South Asia

Film & Text Analysis Guide — Part 2

BANGLADESH

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Mid-Semester Examination | Open Book | Concept-Based Analysis

Use the texts as evidence — not summaries — to explain South Asian concepts.

PART 1 · BANGLADESH · DOCUMENTARIES

The Machinists (2012) & The True Cost (2015)

Dir. Shaheen Dill-Riaz / Dir. Andrew Morgan | Garment industry, labour, global inequality

Context & Synopsis

The Machinists (2012) is a documentary by Shaheen Dill-Riaz that follows garment workers inside Dhaka's factories — their routines, relationships, and working conditions. *The True Cost* (2015), directed by Andrew Morgan, is a global investigation into fast fashion — tracing the journey of a garment from a factory floor in Bangladesh to a mall in the West. Both films are studied together through the lens of the 2013 **Rana Plaza collapse**, in which a garment factory building in Dhaka killed over 1,100 workers — the deadliest garment-industry disaster in history.

Why these films matter for the course: They bring Bangladesh into the frame of global capitalism and the North–South divide. Bangladesh is not just a 'developing country' — it is a node in a global labour network that sustains Western consumer culture.

1.1 Rana Plaza & Global Labour Networks

The Rana Plaza collapse (April 24, 2013) is the defining event that both films orbit. A commercial building in Savar, Dhaka, housing multiple garment factories, collapsed after structural warnings were ignored by building owners and factory managers. Workers — overwhelmingly women — were ordered to return to work despite visible cracks. Over 1,100 died, more than 2,500 were injured.

Global labour networks: The factories in Rana Plaza produced garments for major Western brands — Primark, Walmart, Benetton. This is the defining feature of contemporary global capitalism: **production is outsourced to the Global South** where labour costs are low, safety regulations are weak, and workers have limited power. The profit flows to the Global North; the risk and suffering stay in Bangladesh.

North–South inequality: This is the structural context. Bangladesh is one of the world's leading garment exporters — the industry accounts for over 80% of export earnings. Yet the workers who make this wealth possible are paid poverty wages and work in dangerous conditions. This is not an accident but the logic of global capitalism: the South produces cheaply so the North can consume cheaply.

Key South Asian connection:

Bangladesh's garment industry is a product of its post-independence developmental trajectory. After 1971, Bangladesh (formerly East Pakistan) emerged as an independent nation — one of the poorest in the world. The garment industry was developed as a path to economic growth. This is Bangladesh's integration into global capitalism, and the films ask: at what cost?

1.2 Labour Hazards & The Social Process of Labouring

Labour hazards are not simply physical risks — they are products of social and economic relations. The workers in Rana Plaza faced structural hazards: a building they knew was unsafe, managers who threatened them with withheld wages if they refused to enter, a system in which their lives were worth less than a production deadline.

The social process of labouring means understanding labour not just as economic activity but as a social practice embedded in relationships of power, gender, class, and global capital. In *The Machinists*, we see how the factory organizes social life: workers' friendships, marriages, daily rhythms, aspirations. Labour is not just work — it shapes identity, community, and subjectivity.

Gender and labour: The vast majority of garment workers in Bangladesh are women — approximately 80%. This is not coincidental. Women are preferred because they are considered more 'docile,' easier to discipline, and less likely to unionize. The garment industry reproduces gender hierarchies: women do the unskilled sewing; men hold supervisory positions.

1.3 Dignity of Labour vs. Exploitation

The Machinists takes a crucial formal choice: it does not present workers as victims to be pitied. It shows them as **full human beings** with pride in their work, complex relationships, humor, and ambition. This is the **dignity of labour** — the recognition that labour is meaningful and that labourers are not simply instruments of capital.

The tension arises because the system these workers are embedded in is one of **exploitation**: their labour produces enormous value, but they receive a fraction of it. Dignity and exploitation are not opposites — they coexist. This is the film's central political insight: you can respect a worker and still recognize that the system exploiting them is unjust.

Link to margin-centre: The garment worker is the ultimate marginal figure in global capitalism — producing goods she cannot afford, in conditions no one at the centre of the supply chain would accept for themselves. The films make the margin visible to the centre.

1.4 Critique of Technocratic Solutions

Technocratic solutions are responses to structural problems that address symptoms rather than causes. After Rana Plaza, Western brands and governments proposed solutions: better building inspections, fire safety audits, corporate social responsibility (CSR) programmes. These are technocratic: they treat the problem as a technical failure (bad building) rather than a structural one (a global system that values profit over workers' lives).

The True Cost is explicitly critical of these solutions. The film argues that as long as fast fashion brands compete on low prices, the pressure on factories to cut costs (including safety costs) will remain. No number of inspections can fix a system structurally designed to externalize costs onto workers in the Global South.

Culture as process in fashion: The fashion industry creates constant cultural demand for new styles — 'fast fashion' means producing 52 'micro-seasons' per year rather than the traditional two. This is culture (fashion trends) being used to drive economic exploitation. Culture as process: fashion culture is continuously manufactured to maintain consumption.

1.5 Bangladesh as an Emerging South Asian Tiger

The term '**South Asian tiger**' references the 'Asian tiger' economies (South Korea, Taiwan, Singapore, Hong Kong) that achieved rapid industrialization in the late 20th century. Bangladesh's garment-led economic growth has made it one of the fastest-growing economies in South Asia — it has consistently outperformed its larger neighbours on certain development indicators.

Development of a national consciousness: Bangladesh's identity as a nation is deeply tied to its 1971 Liberation War against Pakistan — a war fought for linguistic and cultural rights (the Bengali language). This national consciousness is relevant to understanding why Bangladesh pursues economic independence through the garment industry: it is not just economics but a statement of national self-determination.

The contradiction: Bangladesh's economic 'success' is built on the exploitation of its own workers for Western consumption. The films ask whether this constitutes genuine development or merely a new form of global inequality — the South developing *for* the North, not for itself.

Key Argument for Bangladesh:

The *Machinists* and *The True Cost* together argue that Bangladesh's garment industry makes visible the structural violence of global capitalism — a system in which North–South inequality is not a side effect but a structural requirement. The films use the dignity of actual workers to challenge technocratic responses and demand structural change. Bangladesh is not a victim of globalisation — it is an active agent whose story exposes the costs of the global economic system that benefits the centre.

PART 2 · BHUTAN · NOVEL

The Circle of Karma

Kunzang Choden | First novel written in English by a Bhutanese woman | Buddhism & modernity

Context & Synopsis

The Circle of Karma (2005) by Kunzang Choden is the first novel written in English by a Bhutanese woman. It follows Tsomo, a young woman born into a poor rural family in Bhutan, who suffers repeated hardships — an abusive marriage, poverty, loss — and makes a series of journeys across Bhutan and to India, always seeking something she cannot name. The novel is structured around the Buddhist concept of karma: Tsomo's suffering and her responses to it are understood through a karmic framework.

Why this text matters: Bhutan is one of the least-studied countries in South Asian studies. The novel offers a rare insider perspective — written from within Bhutanese culture — on how Buddhism shapes everyday life and especially women's experiences.

2.1 Buddhism in Contemporary Bhutan: Cultural & Social Context

Bhutan is a **Buddhist kingdom** — Buddhism is not just a religion but the organizing framework of social life, governance, and cultural identity. The Bhutanese state's famous 'Gross National Happiness' policy is itself rooted in Buddhist values: that wellbeing is more important than economic growth.

In the novel, Buddhism is not an abstract philosophy but a **lived practice**: daily rituals, pilgrimage, the monastery, prayer flags, offerings. Tsomo's entire understanding of her own life — why she suffers, what she should do — is filtered through Buddhist cultural forms. This is the course's concept of **culture as process** in action: Buddhism is not a static religion but a living cultural system that organizes experience, shapes choices, and provides meaning.

Tension between spirituality and materiality: The novel explores what happens when Buddhist values (detachment, acceptance, karma) meet material need (poverty, hunger, survival). Tsomo cannot simply accept her poverty as karma — she must also act to survive. The tension between spiritual framework and material reality is the 'location of culture' in the novel: culture lives in this gap between ideal and lived experience.

2.2 Memory-Based Narrative Structure

The novel is structured around **memory and retrospection**. Tsomo looks back on her life — the narrative moves through time non-linearly, shaped by what she remembers, what she understands, and what she still cannot make sense of. Memory here is not simply a narrative device but a Buddhist one: in Buddhist thought, memory and accumulated experience (karma) are what shape the present moment.

Memory as form of knowledge: The memory-based structure also reflects a specifically Bhutanese narrative tradition — oral storytelling, the passing down of knowledge through memory. The novel's form enacts its content: the story of a woman's life is the story of what she has accumulated and carried.

Connection to course methodology: Like Bhutalia's oral history in the Pakistan unit, the memory narrative privileges embodied, experiential knowledge over official or documentary history. Women's lives — particularly poor rural women — are usually absent from official records. Narrative memory recovers them.

2.3 Body as a Site of Labour and Suffering

Tsomo's body is central to the novel — not as object of desire but as **site of labour and suffering**. She works physically: farming, carrying loads, walking vast distances on pilgrimage. Her body accumulates the traces of hardship — illness, exhaustion, violence from an abusive husband. The body is where social conditions (poverty, patriarchy, physical labour) are materially inscribed.

Link to Bangladesh: Like the garment workers in Bangladesh, Tsomo's body is the primary instrument of her labour and the primary site of her exploitation. In both cases, the female body in the Global South bears disproportionate physical cost. The course consistently returns to the body as the point where social structures become personally and physically real.

Pilgrimage as bodily practice: Tsomo's pilgrimages are not just religious events — they are also acts of physical endurance and geographic transgression. A poor rural woman walking hundreds of miles alone is crossing social as well as physical boundaries. The body in motion is a form of agency.

2.4 Karma as Culturally Embedded Epistemology

Epistemology means a way of knowing — how a society or community understands and organizes experience. Karma is not just a religious doctrine in the novel; it is an **epistemological framework**: it tells Tsomo *why* things happen, what they mean, and what she should do in response.

Karma as structuring principle: The novel's circular structure (the 'circle' of karma) reflects karmic logic: actions create consequences that return to the actor. Tsomo's life is understood as a series of karmic transactions — her suffering is both meaningful (it has a cause in past actions) and purposeful (it generates merit for future lives). This is a fundamentally different relationship to suffering than Western frameworks of individualism or rights.

Productive and limiting functions of karma: Karma is *productive* in that it gives Tsomo a framework for enduring suffering without despair — she understands her pain as part of a larger cosmic process. It is *limiting* in that it can discourage challenging unjust conditions: if suffering is karmic, is resistance futile or even wrong? The novel does not resolve this tension — it inhabits it honestly.

Productive function of karma:

Provides meaning, endurance, moral framework. Tsomo does not collapse under suffering because karma gives it purpose. This is culture enabling survival.

Limiting function of karma:

Can justify acceptance of injustice: 'this is my karma.' Structural oppression (poverty, patriarchy) may be misread as personal karmic debt rather than social failure.

2.5 Everyday Practice of Karma: Instances from the Novel

The novel's power lies in how it shows karma not as abstract theology but as **everyday practice**: the small acts of kindness, the decisions made in difficult situations, the ways Tsomo responds to being wronged. When her husband beats her, when she is cheated, when she helps a stranger on the road — each act is understood by Tsomo as a karmic moment.

Cultural specificity: The novel resists the Western tendency to read Buddhist practice through an exotic or mystical lens. Karma for Tsomo is as ordinary as paying a bill — it is the currency of moral life, integrated into decisions about food, travel, relationships, and work. This is the course's concept of culture as process: Buddhism is not a monument but a daily practice, continuously enacted.

Key Argument for The Circle of Karma:

The Circle of Karma demonstrates that in Bhutan, karma functions as a culturally embedded epistemology — a complete system for organizing, interpreting, and responding to experience. The novel does not celebrate or condemn this framework but shows its productive and limiting functions through Tsomo's lived experience. It also argues that Bhutanese women's lives — poor, rural, bodily — are a legitimate and important subject of literary and scholarly attention: the margin making its own story.

PART 3 · SRI LANKA · NOVEL

Funny Boy (1994)

Shyam Selvadurai | Sri Lankan Civil War | Sexuality, ethnicity, and exclusion

Context & Synopsis

Funny Boy (1994) by Shyam Selvadurai is a coming-of-age novel set in Colombo, Sri Lanka, from the 1970s through the 1983 anti-Tamil riots (Black July). The protagonist, Arjie, is a Tamil boy who is also gay — 'funny' in the family's euphemistic usage. The novel traces his growing awareness of both his sexuality and the escalating ethnic conflict between the Sinhalese majority and Tamil minority, culminating in the riots that destroy his family's home and force their emigration.

Why this text matters: It is one of the few South Asian novels to explicitly address homosexuality as intersecting with ethnic and political identity. It refuses to separate the 'personal' from the 'political' — Arjie's sexuality and his ethnicity are both forms of excluded identity in a society that demands conformity.

3.1 Sri Lankan Conflict: Religious, Ethnic, and Territorial Tensions

Sri Lanka's civil conflict is one of the most prolonged in South Asian history, running from 1983 to 2009. It pitted the **Sinhalese-Buddhist majority** against the **Tamil minority** — primarily Hindu Tamils in the north and east. The conflict had roots in colonial-era policies (the British favoured Tamils in administration) and post-independence Sinhalese Buddhist nationalism.

Territorial dimension: The Tamil militant movement (LTTE / Tamil Tigers) sought a separate homeland in the north — Eelam. The conflict was thus also about **territory**: who controls the land, who belongs where. This connects to the course's concept of **borders and territoriality** — the border between 'Sinhalese Sri Lanka' and 'Tamil territory' was contested violently.

Religious dimension: Sinhalese Buddhist nationalism used religion to define national identity — to be truly Sri Lankan was to be Sinhalese and Buddhist. Tamils, as Hindus (or Christians), were excluded from this definition. Religion became a marker of territorial and ethnic belonging, weaponized in a political conflict.

Black July 1983: The novel culminates in this event — anti-Tamil pogroms in which Sinhalese mobs attacked Tamil civilians across Sri Lanka. The riots were organized and politically facilitated. Over 3,000 Tamils were killed; hundreds of thousands fled. This is the **everyday reproduction of conflict** becoming catastrophic violence.

3.2 Intersection of Ethnicity and Sexuality: Double Exclusion

Arjie is doubly excluded: as a **Tamil** in a Sinhalese-dominated state, and as a **gay boy** in a heteronormative family and society. The novel maps how these two forms of exclusion work in parallel and interact with each other.

Double exclusion as analytic framework: Arjie cannot be fully at home anywhere. In Sinhalese spaces, he is Tamil — marked, suspect, in danger. In Tamil family space, he is 'funny' — non-conforming, a source of shame. His sexuality and his ethnicity are both identities that the dominant order demands he suppress or deny.

Intersection of oppressions: The course framework of margin-centre is relevant here: Arjie is doubly marginal. But the novel shows that these margins are not simply additive — they interact in complex ways. Being Tamil shapes how his gender non-conformity is experienced; being gay shapes how he experiences ethnic violence. The two identities cannot be separated.

The personal as political: Selvadurai refuses the separation of private (sexual) identity from public (ethnic/political) identity. Arjie's coming-of-age is inseparable from Sri Lanka's political breakdown. The personal experience of exclusion and the political experience of communal violence are the same story.

3.3 Intimate Geopolitics: Spatial Relations and Modes of Interaction

Intimate geopolitics is a framework that examines how large-scale political conflicts — wars, ethnic tensions, state violence — are reproduced in **intimate, everyday spaces**: the family home, the school, the neighborhood, the body.

In *Funny Boy*, the Sri Lankan conflict enters the home gradually. At first it is distant — news, adult conversations, tension at school. Then it enters more intimately: a cross-ethnic love relationship Arjie witnesses, the family's mixed-race social world fracturing under political pressure, and finally the destruction of the home itself in the riots. The geopolitical becomes intimate.

Spatial relations: The novel is organized around spaces — the family compound, the school, the beach house, the mixed neighbourhood. Each space has its own social rules about who belongs and who doesn't. Arjie navigates these spaces as someone who never fully belongs in any of them. Space in the novel is a map of social inclusion and exclusion.

Modes of interaction: The novel shows how ethnic conflict is reproduced through ordinary interactions — who sits with whom at school, which families visit, what jokes are made. Violence does not arrive suddenly: it is prepared by hundreds of small acts of differentiation and exclusion. The everyday reproduction of conflict precedes and enables its catastrophic forms.

3.4 Everyday Reproduction of Conflict

One of the novel's most important arguments is that ethnic violence is not an eruption from nowhere — it is the product of everyday practices of differentiation, prejudice, and exclusion that accumulate over time. **Black July did not happen suddenly:** it was prepared by decades of discriminatory legislation, Sinhalese Buddhist nationalism in education and media, and the everyday marking of Tamils as 'other.'

The novel makes this visible at the micro-level: the changing atmosphere at school, the Tamil family's discomfort at Sinhalese events, the increasing impossibility of cross-ethnic friendships. Arjie is a witness and participant in this gradual hardening — and his own experience of exclusion (as a non-conforming boy) makes him particularly sensitive to the mechanisms of social exclusion operating at a larger scale.

Key Argument for Funny Boy:

Funny Boy argues that ethnic and sexual exclusion are not separate political problems but intersecting ones, reproduced through everyday intimate practices. Sri Lanka's civil conflict enters the domestic space gradually, through intimate geopolitics — transforming how families live, love, and understand themselves before it erupts into catastrophic violence. Arjie's double marginality (Tamil + gay) makes him the ideal witness to a society in the process of tearing itself apart through the mechanism of exclusion.

PART 4 · NEPAL · SHORT TEXT

Hands

Dream narrative | Political allegory | Nepal's marginality in South Asia

Context & Framing

Hands is a short text from the Nepal unit, read as a **dream narrative** with allegorical dimensions. Nepal is one of the least-studied countries in South Asian studies — marginalized within the region itself, despite its strategic location between India and China and its rich cultural and political history. The text is also an occasion to reflect on **canon formation**: which literary and cultural texts are studied and why, and what it means to 'do' South Asian studies when some South Asian nations are almost entirely absent from the curriculum.

4.1 Dream Narrative as Form

A **dream narrative** operates by different rules than realist fiction. In a dream narrative, logic can be suspended, time collapses, images carry symbolic weight rather than literal meaning, and the boundary between self and other becomes unstable. This form allows the text to work allegorically — individual experience becomes representative of collective or political realities.

Why this form for Nepal? Dream narratives are well suited to representing experiences that cannot be fully articulated in realist terms — trauma, aspiration, political longing, the experience of marginality. Nepal's position in South Asia (marginal, often overlooked, squeezed between two giants) may be expressible in the condensed, symbolic language of the dream in ways that a realist narrative cannot capture.

Reading the form: When encountering a dream narrative, the key analytical move is to ask: what does each image or figure represent? What is the emotional logic? What is the dream *about* at a deeper level than its surface content? This is 'reading silence' in another mode — reading what the text communicates through symbol and form rather than explicit statement.

4.2 Intergenerational Conflict as Political Allegory

Intergenerational conflict — tension between older and younger generations — is used in the text as a **political allegory**: the conflict between generations represents the conflict between old orders and new aspirations, tradition and modernity, political stasis and the desire for change.

Nepal's political history makes this allegory resonant: Nepal was an absolute monarchy until 1990, then a constitutional monarchy, and underwent a Maoist insurgency (1996–2006) that was fundamentally a generational and class conflict — young rural people challenging an old political order. The republic was declared in 2008. Intergenerational conflict in the text can be read against this backdrop of political transformation.

Allegory as political mode: Allegory allows writers in politically constrained contexts to speak about power without direct confrontation. A story about a son and father can also be a story about citizens and the state, the old order and the new. This is a form of agency within constraint — using narrative indirection to say what direct speech cannot.

4.3 Symbolism of Hands

The title and central symbol — **hands** — operates on multiple registers simultaneously:

- **Hands as labour:** Hands are the primary instrument of physical work. In a predominantly agrarian and labouring society like Nepal, hands represent the working body — the source of survival and dignity.
- **Hands as relation:** Hands reach toward others, hold, strike, offer, withdraw. The symbolism of hands in intergenerational relationships — a father's hand, a son's hand — carries the weight of authority, care, violence, and inheritance.
- **Hands as agency:** To have hands is to be able to act — to make, build, resist. Hands as symbol of human capacity and the possibility of change.
- **Hands as loss:** If hands are harmed, lost, or idle, this represents devastation — of livelihood, dignity, and relational capacity. The symbolic register of injury to hands is particularly powerful in labour contexts.

Reading the symbolism of hands requires attending to each context in which they appear in the text — whose hands, doing what, to whom. The image accumulates meaning across its appearances.

4.4 Nepal's Marginality in South Asia

Nepal is marginalized within South Asia in several senses: it is a small, landlocked, mountainous country without direct sea access. It is economically dependent on India (which controls its trade routes). It has been historically subject to Indian influence in politics. The **margin-centre framework** operates at the regional level: Nepal is a margin within South Asia, which is itself a margin in the global system.

Marginality and migration: Nepal is one of the largest sources of labour migrants in the region — millions of Nepalis work in India, the Gulf states, and elsewhere. This is the diaspora concept applied to Nepal: a country whose people are forced by economic marginality to labour in other countries, often in dangerous and exploitative conditions (see: Qatar World Cup construction deaths). The body labouring abroad is a symbol of Nepal's structural position.

Marginality within Nepal: Nepal itself has its own internal hierarchies — caste, ethnicity (Brahmin-Chhetri at the top; Dalit communities at the bottom), geography (Kathmandu valley vs. remote hills and Terai). The text's intergenerational conflict may also speak to these internal margins.

4.5 Canon Formation: Literature and Culture as Academic Endeavours

Canon formation refers to the process by which certain texts come to be considered 'important,' 'representative,' or 'significant' — and are therefore taught, studied, translated, and preserved. The canon is not natural: it is produced through institutional decisions (what universities teach), commercial decisions (what gets published and distributed), and political decisions (whose culture counts).

The Nepal unit asks: **why is Nepali literature almost entirely absent from South Asian studies curricula?** This is a question about canon formation. Nepal's marginality in the global publishing and academic system mirrors its marginality in the region. There is a circular logic: Nepali texts are not taught because they are not translated; they are not translated because there is no perceived demand; there is no demand because they are not taught.

Literature and culture as academic endeavours: The course itself is an academic practice that includes or excludes certain texts and countries. By including Nepal (however briefly), the syllabus makes an argument: South Asian studies must attend to its own blind spots, its own internal canons, its own reproduction of centre-margin hierarchies.

Key Argument for Hands / Nepal:

The Nepal unit uses Hands to raise the meta-question of the course: whose stories count as South Asian literature, and why? Nepal's absence from the South Asian canon is itself an argument about the margin-centre framework operating at the level of academic knowledge production. The text's dream narrative and political allegory suggest that what cannot be said directly in Nepal's constrained political history must be said through symbol and form.

PART 5 · INDIA · NOVEL

The White Tiger (2008)

Aravind Adiga | Booker Prize winner | Neoliberalism, class, and the entrepreneur

Context & Synopsis

The White Tiger (2008) by Aravind Adiga won the Booker Prize. It is narrated by Balram Halwai, a man from the rural 'Darkness' of Bihar who becomes a driver for a wealthy Delhi family, eventually murders his employer Ashok, and uses the stolen money to become a successful entrepreneur in Bangalore. The novel is structured as a letter from Balram to the Premier of China — a framing device that immediately positions it as a meditation on capitalism, development, and the promise of economic modernity.

Why this text matters: It is one of the most explicit literary engagements with post-liberalisation India — the India of IT, call centres, and rising GDP alongside persistent extreme poverty. It asks whether the promise of neoliberalism is available to everyone, or only to those who are willing to commit violence to escape their structural position.

5.1 Neoliberal Economic Framework and Its Promise

Neoliberalism is the dominant economic ideology of the late 20th and 21st centuries: it promotes free markets, privatization, deregulation, and individual entrepreneurialism as the path to prosperity. Its promise is that anyone, regardless of birth, can succeed through hard work, intelligence, and initiative.

India's post-1991 economic liberalisation opened the economy, produced the IT boom, created a new middle class, and generated extraordinary wealth in cities like Bangalore, Mumbai, and Delhi. This is the neoliberal promise: economic growth lifts all boats. India's global image transformed — from 'developing country' to 'emerging economy,' from aid recipient to technology powerhouse.

The White Tiger and the neoliberal promise: Balram embodies the neoliberal ideal — a self-made man who escapes poverty through his own initiative. But the novel shows the *actual cost* of this escape: it requires murder. The neoliberal promise of upward mobility, the novel argues, is available only through transgression for those born in the 'Darkness.' The promise is real but structurally inaccessible through legitimate means.

5.2 Narrative Structure and Its Importance

The novel's narrative structure is itself a political statement. Balram narrates from a position of success — we know from the beginning that he has 'made it.' This creates a specific readerly position: we know the outcome, so the question is not 'what happens' but '*how does it happen, and what does it cost?*'

Epistolary form (letter to Premier): Writing to China's Premier positions Balram's story as a contribution to a global conversation about capitalism and development. India and China are both 'rising' economic powers in the same period. The letter form also positions Balram as an authority — he knows something the Premier needs to hear. This is a marginal man claiming the authority to speak to power.

Unreliable narrator: Balram is a murderer, and he tells us so. The reader must decide how to evaluate his account. The novel refuses to give us a stable moral position from which to judge Balram — he is simultaneously victim and perpetrator, sympathetic and monstrous. This moral ambiguity is political: it prevents easy condemnation of Balram without also condemning the system that produced him.

5.3 Spatial Structure: Light and Darkness, Transgression Between Both

The novel organizes Indian space into two zones: the '**Darkness**' and the '**Light**.' The Darkness is rural India — Bihar, Balram's home — characterized by poverty, caste hierarchy, corruption, and stagnation. The Light is urban India — Delhi, Bangalore — characterized by wealth, technology, aspiration, and opportunity. This is a spatial version of the margin-centre framework.

The spatial structure reproduces inequality: The geography of India is not natural — it is produced. The Darkness is dark not because of inherent cultural failure but because of structural neglect: the post-liberalisation Indian state has invested in cities and IT infrastructure while rural areas remain mired in poverty and feudal social relations.

Transgression between zones: Balram's journey from Darkness to Light is not legitimate migration — it is transgression. He crosses the spatial boundary through violence (murder) because the social systems (the rooster coop) prevent legitimate crossing. The spatial structure is maintained by social mechanisms that prevent those born in Darkness from entering the Light through normal means.

The 'Darkness':

Rural Bihar. Caste hierarchies. Feudal landlords (the 'Stork', the 'Buffalo'). Balram's family. Poverty as inherited condition. No access to education or opportunity.

The 'Light':

Delhi and Bangalore. Wealthy employers. IT industry. New India's aspiration. Apparent meritocracy. The space Balram desires and eventually inhabits — through murder.

5.4 The Rooster Coop

The **rooster coop** is Balram's central metaphor for the social mechanism that keeps poor Indians in their place. He describes seeing roosters in a coop at a market: they can see the other roosters being slaughtered but do not try to escape. They do not run because they cannot imagine escape — or because they have been so thoroughly conditioned to their position that resistance is unthinkable.

The coop as ideology: The rooster coop is not maintained primarily by physical force but by **ideology** — the beliefs that servants internalize about their place in the social order. Balram's family members are loyal to the Stork (their landlord) even when he exploits them, because they cannot conceive of a world in which they would not be servants. The coop is in their minds as much as in social structure.

The coop and neoliberalism: The rooster coop exposes the lie of neoliberal meritocracy: mobility is not simply a matter of individual effort or intelligence. It requires escaping a social conditioning so deep it functions like instinct. Balram is different from other roosters not because he is more capable but because he can *think* outside the coop — and then act, violently.

Link to Margin–Centre: The rooster coop is the mechanism by which the centre (landlords, employers, the wealthy) maintains the margin (servants, the poor) without constant physical coercion. It is a theory of how structural power reproduces itself through the consciousness of the marginalized.

5.5 Balram as the White Tiger and as Entrepreneur

The **white tiger** is a rare animal — in the novel, it is a metaphor for someone born once in a generation who is truly exceptional. Balram applies this label to himself — he is the rare individual who can see through the rooster coop and break out of it. This self-mythologization is both Balram's strength (his confidence and self-belief) and a sign of the ideological trap he has not entirely escaped: he explains his own success through exceptional individual qualities rather than structural luck and violence.

Balram as entrepreneur: The novel ends with Balram running a successful taxi company in Bangalore — he is now an employer, not an employee. He has internalized and reproduced the capitalist structure: he is now on the other side of the class divide. The novel's final irony is that Balram has not overthrown the system — he has joined it. His success is individual, not collective. The rooster coop for his own workers remains intact.

The entrepreneur in neoliberal ideology: Entrepreneurialism is the highest value in neoliberal culture — the self-made individual who creates value and succeeds through initiative. Balram achieves this ideal. But the novel asks: is this a victory for the marginalized, or simply the reproduction of exploitation with a new person on top?

Key Argument for The White Tiger:

The *White Tiger* is a sustained critique of neoliberalism's promise: it shows that upward mobility from the 'Darkness' of structural poverty requires not just individual effort but the violation of the social bonds (loyalty, family, service) that hold the rooster coop in place — and ultimately, violence. Balram's success is real but achieved through means that expose the system's violence rather than transcending it. The novel uses narrative structure, spatial metaphor, and the rooster coop to map how class inequality reproduces itself in post-liberalisation India.

CROSS-TEXT CONNECTIONS — ALL FIVE COUNTRIES

The strongest exam answers draw connections across texts and countries. Here are the most powerful links:

Bangladesh ↔ India

Both deal with **labour and capitalism** — but at different scales and through different forms. The garment workers in Bangladesh are exploited by global capital; Balram in India is exploited by domestic capital and the caste-class system. In both, the **margin-centre framework** explains structural inequality. Both also interrogate the promise of development: Bangladesh as 'South Asian tiger,' India as 'rising economy.' Both texts ask who actually benefits from this growth.

Nepal ↔ Bangladesh

Both texts speak to **labour migration and the body as site of exploitation**. Nepali workers migrate to India and the Gulf; Bangladeshi garment workers labour for Western brands. In both cases, the Global South body labours for the benefit of more powerful actors. The Nepal unit also raises the question of **canon formation** — why Bangladesh's story is more globally visible (Rana Plaza made international news) while Nepal remains obscure.

Funny Boy ↔ Osama (from Part 1)

Both texts centre protagonists who are **doubly marginalized**: Arjie as Tamil + gay; the girl in Osama as female + impersonating a boy. Both show how **identity is policed** by political regimes — Sri Lankan ethnic nationalism; Taliban gender enforcement. Both use the private/intimate sphere as the site where political violence is first felt. Both refuse triumphant resolution.

Bhutan ↔ Sri Lanka (karma vs. conflict)

An unlikely but powerful pairing: both texts deal with how **cultural frameworks** organize responses to suffering. In Bhutan, karma provides a framework for enduring and making sense of hardship. In Sri Lanka, ethnic identity provides a framework for organizing violence. Both are **culturally embedded epistemologies**: ways of knowing that structure action. The comparison reveals that culture organizes experience in both productive and destructive directions — culture as process.

The White Tiger ↔ The Circle of Karma

Both texts deal with **poverty, suffering, and the possibility of escape**. Tsomo endures suffering within a karmic framework that finds meaning in it. Balram refuses acceptance and escapes through violence. Two radically different responses to structural marginality — one rooted in Buddhist epistemology, one in neoliberal individualism. The comparison asks: what frameworks does a society offer for responding to poverty, and what actions do they enable or foreclose?

EXAM ANSWER TEMPLATES — PART 2 TEXTS

Labour, Exploitation, and North–South Inequality (Bangladesh)

[Concept: e.g., labour hazards as social process] refers to... The Machinists / The True Cost illustrates this through [specific element: e.g., the Rana Plaza collapse, the role of global brands]. This demonstrates [analysis: structural violence, not individual failure]. Connect to [neoliberalism / margin-centre / India's White Tiger] by [link].

Cultural Epistemology and Karma (Bhutan)

Karma functions in The Circle of Karma not as mere religious belief but as [definition: an epistemological framework that organizes experience]. This is visible in [instance from novel]. The productive function is [analysis], but the limiting function is [analysis]. This connects to the course concept of [culture as process / tension between spirituality and materiality] because [link].

Double Exclusion and Intimate Geopolitics (Sri Lanka)

Funny Boy demonstrates [concept: e.g., double exclusion / intimate geopolitics] through [specific example from novel]. The intersection of [ethnicity + sexuality] creates [analysis]. The everyday reproduction of conflict is visible through [specific scene/interaction]. This connects to [Osama / margin-centre] because [link].

Canon Formation and Marginality (Nepal)

The Nepal unit raises the question of [concept: canon formation] — the process by which [definition]. Nepal's absence from South Asian literary scholarship demonstrates the [margin-centre framework] operating at the level of [academic knowledge production]. The text Hands uses [dream narrative / allegory] to [analysis]. This formal choice matters because [link to political/cultural context].

Neoliberalism and Class Mobility (India)

The White Tiger engages with the neoliberal promise of [definition: meritocracy, entrepreneurialism, upward mobility]. Through [Balram / the rooster coop / spatial metaphor of Light and Darkness], Adiga argues [analysis: mobility requires transgression, the coop reproduces inequality through ideology]. Connect to [Bangladesh / Nepal / margin-centre] by [link: all deal with structural poverty and the mechanisms of its reproduction].

Remember: name the concept → apply to South Asia broadly → cite the text as evidence → analyze, don't summarize → connect across texts.